十二生肖

除夕晚上奶奶讲的老故事

The Twelve Animals

Grandma's old story on New Year's Eve

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 3 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 除夕[†]晚上，小宇[‡]一家人都在奶奶家吃年夜饭[§]。外面很冷，屋子里很暖和。桌子上有鱼，有饺子，还有奶奶做的很多菜。电视里正在放春节晚会，大人们一边吃一边说，可是两个孩子一点儿也不看电视，因为他们正在吵架。

你属什么？

2 “老鼠[¶]又小又脏，大家都不喜欢它！”八岁的小宇大声说，“你属鼠[*]，哈哈！”六岁的妹妹小月[#]马上生气了：“属鼠有什么不好？你属狗，狗只会叫！”“狗是人的好朋友，它会看门，还跑得很快。老鼠会什么？老鼠只会吃别人家的米！”小月说不过哥哥，眼睛都红了。

† 除夕 *Chúxī* New Year's Eve
‡ 小宇 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu (a boy)
§ 年夜饭 *niányèfàn* New Year's Eve dinner
¶ 老鼠 *lǎoshǔ* mouse, rat
* 鼠 *shǔ* rat (zodiac)
\# 小月 *Xiǎoyuè* Xiaoyue, Xiaoyu's sister

On New Year's Eve, Xiaoyu's whole family was at Grandma's home for the New Year's Eve dinner. It was cold outside, but warm in the house. On the table there was fish, there were dumplings, and there were many other dishes Grandma had made. The Spring Festival Gala was on TV, and the grown-ups talked as they ate, but the two children weren't watching TV at all, because they were in the middle of a quarrel. 1

What's Your Animal?

"Rats are small and dirty, and nobody likes them!" said eight-year-old Xiaoyu loudly. "You're a Rat, ha ha!" His six-year-old sister Xiaoyue got angry at once. "What's wrong with being a Rat? You're a Dog, and dogs can only bark!" "Dogs are people's good friends. They guard the house, and they run fast. What can rats do? All rats can do is eat other people's rice!" Xiaoyue couldn't out-argue her brother, and her eyes went red. 2

3 奶奶在旁边听了很久，这时候笑着问："小宇[†]，你知道十二生肖[‡]里谁是第一吗？""第一？当然是龙！龙会飞，什么都不怕。""不对，"奶奶说，"第一是老鼠[§]。"小宇不相信："老鼠那么小，连猫都怕，它怎么能是第一？到底为什么？"小月[¶]一听奶奶的话，就不哭了，高兴地说："奶奶，你快讲讲！"奶奶喝了一口茶，说："好，那我就给你们讲一个很老很老的故事。"

一场比赛

4 很久很久以前，人们还不知道怎么给每一年起名字。天上的玉皇大帝[*]想了一个办法：选十二种动物，每种动物管一年，十二年以后，再从第一个开始。可是选哪十二种呢？玉皇大帝告诉大家：他要办一场比赛，所有的动物都可以参加。

† 小宇 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu (a boy)
‡ 生肖 *shēngxiào* Chinese zodiac animals
§ 老鼠 *lǎoshǔ* mouse, rat
¶ 小月 *Xiǎoyuè* Xiaoyue, Xiaoyu's sister
* 玉皇大帝 *Yùhuáng Dàdì* the Jade Emperor

Grandma had been listening nearby for a long time. Now she asked with a smile, "Xiaoyu, do you know who comes first among the twelve zodiac animals?" "First? The Dragon, of course! Dragons can fly, and they aren't afraid of anything." "No," said Grandma. "First is the Rat." Xiaoyu didn't believe it. "Rats are so small they're even afraid of cats. How can a rat be first? Why on earth?" As soon as she heard what Grandma said, Xiaoyue stopped crying. "Grandma, tell us, quick!" she said happily. Grandma took a sip of tea and said, "All right, then I'll tell you a very, very old story." 3

A Race

Long, long ago, people didn't yet know how to give each year a name. The Jade Emperor in heaven thought of a way: he would choose twelve kinds of animals, each animal would look after one year, and after twelve years it would start again from the first. But which twelve should he choose? The Jade Emperor told everyone that he would hold a race, and all the animals could take part. 4

4 比赛那天早上，大家要过一条大河，先到河对面的十二种动物，就能成为生肖†。

5 那时候，猫和老鼠‡是好朋友。它们都想参加比赛，可是都不会游泳。因为它们个子很小，河又大又深，所以它们不知道怎么办。老鼠想了很久，想出了一个好办法：“牛又会游泳，又愿意帮助别人，我们可以请牛背我们过河。”猫说：“好主意！比赛那天早上，你一起床就来叫我，好吗？”老鼠说：“好，没问题。”

6 比赛那天，天还没亮，老鼠就起床了。它看了看旁边的猫，猫还睡得很香。老鼠心里想：“猫跑得比我快多了，要是它也去，第一可能就不是我的了。”所以它没有叫猫，自己轻轻地走了。

7 到了河边，牛已经准备下水了。

† 生肖 *shēngxiào* Chinese zodiac animals ‡ 老鼠 *lǎoshǔ* mouse, rat

On the morning of the race, everyone had to cross a big river, and the first twelve animals to reach the other side would become the zodiac animals. 4

In those days, the cat and the rat were good friends. They both wanted to enter the race, but neither of them could swim. Because they were so small and the river was so big and deep, they didn't know what to do. The rat thought for a long time and came up with a good idea. "The ox can swim, and he's happy to help others. We can ask the ox to carry us across the river on his back." "Good idea!" said the cat. "On the morning of the race, come and wake me as soon as you get up, all right?" "Sure, no problem," said the rat. 5

On the day of the race, the rat got up before it was light. It looked at the cat beside it; the cat was still fast asleep. The rat thought to itself, "The cat runs much faster than I do. If it comes too, first place may not be mine." So it didn't wake the cat, and quietly left on its own. 6

When it reached the river, the ox was already getting ready to go into the water. 7

7 老鼠[†]跳到牛的背上，说：“牛哥哥，你背我过河吧。我很轻，你不会觉得累的。”牛没想太多，就答应了。牛游得很慢，可是一直没有停。快到河对面的时候，老鼠突然从牛的头上跳了下来，第一个跑到了玉皇大帝[‡]的面前。就这样，最小的老鼠成了第一名，牛只能是第二名。

8 后来，别的动物也一个一个地到了。老虎[§]很会游泳，是第三。兔子[¶]在河里的石头上跳来跳去，是第四。龙会飞，本来应该比大家都快，可是它在路上看见一个地方很久没有下雨了，就停下来给那里的人下了一场雨，所以只拿了第五。

9 蛇[*]一直在马的腿上，快到的时候突然出来了。马一看见蛇，就害怕地停了下来，所以蛇是第六，马是第七。羊、猴子[#]和鸡找到了一块大木头，一起过了河，是第八、第九和第十。狗特别喜欢玩水，在河里玩了很久，是第十一。

† 老鼠 *lǎoshǔ* mouse, rat
‡ 玉皇大帝 *Yùhuáng Dàdì* the Jade Emperor
§ 老虎 *lǎohǔ* tiger
¶ 兔子 *tùzi* rabbit
* 蛇 *shé* snake
猴子 *hóuzi* monkey

The rat jumped onto the ox's back and said, "Brother Ox, carry me across the river. I'm very light, you won't get tired." The ox didn't think twice, and agreed. The ox swam slowly, but it never stopped. Just as they were about to reach the other side, the rat suddenly jumped down off the ox's head and was the first to run up to the Jade Emperor. And so the smallest animal, the rat, came first, and the ox could only be second. 7

After that, the other animals arrived one by one. The tiger was a strong swimmer and came third. The rabbit hopped from stone to stone across the river and came fourth. The dragon could fly and should have been faster than all of them, but on the way it saw a place where it hadn't rained for a long time, so it stopped to bring rain to the people there, and only came fifth. 8

The snake had been clinging to the horse's leg all along, and just before the end it suddenly came out. The moment the horse saw the snake, it stopped in fright, so the snake came sixth and the horse seventh. The goat, the monkey and the rooster found a big log and crossed the river together, coming eighth, ninth and tenth. The dog loved playing in water so much that it played in the river for a long time, and came eleventh. 9

最后来的是猪：它在路上吃饱了，又睡了很久，才慢慢地走过来。

“狗只是第十一？”小月[†]看着哥哥，笑了起来。小宇[‡]有点儿不好意思：“那……那是因为狗喜欢玩儿！”奶奶笑着说：“喜欢玩儿没有什么不好，可是比赛的时候只想着玩儿，就不行了。”小月又问：“那猫呢？猫到底是第几？”

猫和老鼠[§]

奶奶说：“猫啊，一直睡到太阳很高了才起床。”它一看老鼠不在，就知道不好了，马上跑到河边。可是它不会游泳，在河边找了很久，才找到一条小船。等它到了河对面，比赛早就结束了，十二个生肖[¶]都有了，连最慢的猪都比它早到了很久。

† 小月 *Xiǎoyuè* Xiaoyue, Xiaoyu's sister
‡ 小宇 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu (a boy)
§ 老鼠 *lǎoshǔ* mouse, rat
¶ 生肖 *shēngxiào* Chinese zodiac animals

Last of all came the pig: it had eaten its fill on the way, then slept for a long time, and only then did it slowly wander over. 9

"The dog was only eleventh?" Xiaoyue looked at her brother and burst out laughing. Xiaoyu was a little embarrassed. "That... that's because dogs like to play!" Grandma laughed. "There's nothing wrong with liking to play, but if all you think about in a race is playing, that won't do." Then Xiaoyue asked, "What about the cat? So what place did the cat come in?" 10

The Cat and the Rat

Grandma said, "The cat slept until the sun was high in the sky before it got up." As soon as it saw the rat was gone, it knew something was wrong and ran straight to the river. But it couldn't swim, and it searched along the bank for a long time before it found a little boat. By the time it reached the other side, the race had long been over. All twelve zodiac animals had been chosen; even the slowest, the pig, had arrived long before it. 11

12 猫非常生气。它找到老鼠†，大声问：“我们说好了，你要叫我起床，你为什么不叫我？”老鼠一句话也不说，马上就跑。猫就在后面追。从那以后，猫一看见老鼠就追，它们也就不是朋友了。

13 “原来是这样！”小月‡说，“所以现在猫还在抓老鼠。”小宇§想了想，说：“老鼠虽然小，可是很会想办法。不过它不叫猫起床，这是不对的。”奶奶点点头：“小宇说得对。老鼠会想办法，所以拿了第一；可是它也因为这件事，没有了好朋友。”“每个生肖¶都有好的地方，也有不好的地方，人也一样。”

14 奶奶还告诉他们，中国人常常用生肖说年纪。有的人觉得直接问“你多大了”不太好，就问：“你属什么？”

† 老鼠 *lǎoshǔ* mouse, rat
‡ 小月 *Xiǎoyuè* Xiaoyue, Xiaoyu's sister
§ 小宇 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu (a boy)
¶ 生肖 *shēngxiào* Chinese zodiac animals

The cat was furious. It found the rat and shouted, "We agreed you would wake me. Why didn't you?" The rat didn't say a word and ran off at once. The cat chased after it. From then on, whenever the cat saw a rat it gave chase, and that was the end of their friendship. 12

"So that's how it was!" said Xiaoyue. "That's why cats still catch rats today." Xiaoyu thought for a moment and said, "The rat may be small, but it's good at thinking of ways to do things. Still, it was wrong of it not to wake the cat." Grandma nodded. "Xiaoyu is right. The rat was good at finding a way, so it came first; but because of what it did, it also lost a good friend." "Every zodiac animal has its good points and its bad points, and people are the same." 13

Grandma also told them that Chinese people often use the zodiac animals to talk about age. Some people feel it isn't quite polite to ask straight out, "How old are you?", so they ask, "What's your animal?" 14

14 因为每个生肖[1]十二年才出现一次，所以听到别人属什么，再看看他的样子，就能知道他大概多大。

一家人的生肖

15 “那我们来算一算，我们家每个人都属什么！”小宇[2]说。爸爸说：“我属马。你妈妈属羊，比我小一岁。”小月[3]用手指一个一个地数：“鼠[4]、牛、虎[5]、兔[6]、龙、蛇[7]、马、羊……对，马后面就是羊！”“后面还有猴[8]、鸡、狗、猪。”小宇马上说，“狗是我！”

16 “那奶奶呢？奶奶属什么？”小月问。奶奶笑着说：“你们自己算吧。我今年六十六岁。”小宇算了半天也没有算出来：“六十六……太难了！奶奶，你到底属什么啊？”

1 生肖 *shēngxiào* Chinese zodiac animals
2 小宇 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu (a boy)
3 小月 *Xiǎoyuè* Xiaoyue, Xiaoyu's sister
4 鼠 *shǔ* rat (zodiac)
5 虎 *hǔ* tiger (zodiac)
6 兔 *tù* rabbit (zodiac)
7 蛇 *shé* snake
8 猴 *hóu* monkey (zodiac)

Because each animal comes round only once every twelve years, when you hear someone's animal and then look at them, you can tell roughly how old they are. 14

The Family's Animals

"Then let's work out what animal everyone in our family is!" said Xiaoyu. Dad said, "I'm a Horse. Your mum is a Goat; she's a year younger than me." Xiaoyue counted them off on her fingers one by one. "Rat, Ox, Tiger, Rabbit, Dragon, Snake, Horse, Goat... Yes, the Goat comes right after the Horse!" "After that come the Monkey, Rooster, Dog and Pig," Xiaoyu put in at once. "The Dog is me!" 15

"What about Grandma? What's Grandma's animal?" asked Xiaoyue. Grandma smiled and said, "Work it out yourselves. I'm sixty-six this year." Xiaoyu worked at it for ages but couldn't get it. "Sixty-six... it's too hard! Grandma, what is your animal, then?" 16

16 爸爸在旁边说：“我给你一个办法。奶奶六十六岁，小月[†]六岁，她们差了多少岁？”“六十岁。”“六十年里有几个十二年？”“五个……”小宇[‡]的眼睛突然亮了。

17 他看了看奶奶，又看了看妹妹，大声说：“奶奶也属鼠[§]！”奶奶哈哈大笑：“对，我和小月一样，都属鼠。小宇，你刚才说，老鼠[¶]又小又脏，大家都不喜欢。那你喜欢不喜欢奶奶啊？”小宇的脸红了。他走到奶奶身边，说：“喜欢！我最喜欢奶奶了！……也喜欢妹妹。”小月高兴得跳了起来：“你看，连奶奶都属鼠，属鼠最好！”

18 这时候，电视里的人一起大声说：“新年快乐！”十二点到了，新的一年开始了。爸爸举起杯子，笑着说：“今年是马年，是我的本命年[*]。你们两个，今年还吵不吵？”

† 小月 *Xiǎoyuè* Xiaoyue, Xiaoyu's sister
‡ 小宇 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu (a boy)
§ 鼠 *shǔ* rat (zodiac)
¶ 老鼠 *lǎoshǔ* mouse, rat
* 本命年 *běnmìngnián* one's own zodiac year

Dad said from beside him, "I'll give you a hint. Grandma is sixty-six and Xiaoyue is six. How many years apart are they?" "Sixty." "And how many twelves are there in sixty years?" "Five..." Xiaoyu's eyes suddenly lit up. 16

He looked at Grandma, then at his sister, and said loudly, "Grandma's a Rat too!" Grandma laughed heartily. "That's right, Xiaoyue and I are both Rats. Xiaoyu, just now you said rats are small and dirty and nobody likes them. So do you like your grandma or not?" Xiaoyu went red. He went over to Grandma and said, "I do! I like Grandma best of all! ...And I like my sister too." Xiaoyue jumped up happily. "See? Even Grandma is a Rat. Rats are the best!" 17

Just then, the people on TV all called out together, "Happy New Year!" It was twelve o'clock, and the new year had begun. Dad raised his glass and said with a smile, "This is the Year of the Horse, my own animal's year. You two, are you still going to quarrel this year?" 18

18 小宇[†]和小月[‡]看了看对方，一起说：“不吵了！”可是过了不到五分钟，两个人又开始吵了：这次是为了最后一个饺子。

† 小宇 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu (a boy)

‡ 小月 *Xiǎoyuè* Xiaoyue, Xiaoyu's sister

Xiaoyu and Xiaoyue looked at each other and said together, "No more quar- 18
relling!" But less than five minutes later the two of them were at it again: this time over the last dumpling.